

Makop Ransomware targets India

What it actually means and how to stay safe

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India has become the focal point of a growing Makop ransomware campaign, with new research revealing that the country accounts for more than half of all known victims. The trend reflects a broader shift in how ransomware groups operate, prioritising regions where exposed remote access systems, weak cyber hygiene, and delayed security updates remain common. While Makop itself is not new, changes in its delivery methods and a clear focus on Indian organisations have raised fresh concerns about how easily familiar weaknesses continue to be exploited.

A shifting ransomware campaign in India

According to Acronis Research, 55 percent of Makop ransomware victims identified in recent investigations were based in India. This concentration is not random. Attackers tend to target environments where they can gain access quickly and operate with minimal resistance, and many small and mid sized Indian businesses still rely heavily on remote desktop access with limited security controls.

Makop first appeared around 2020 and is part of the Phobos ransomware family, which is known for targeted, hands on attacks rather than mass

email campaigns. Unlike ransomware groups that depend on phishing links or malicious attachments, Makop operators often break directly into systems, giving them greater control over the timing and scope of an attack.

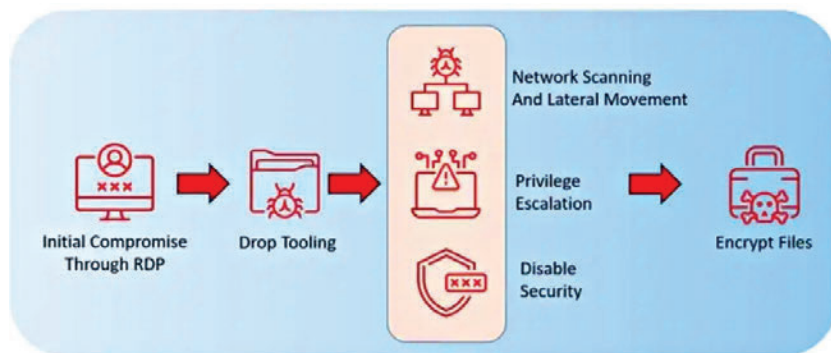
What makes the current wave significant is the scale of activity in India combined with a visible evolution

services. Attackers use automated tools to guess weak passwords or reuse credentials leaked from previous breaches. Once access is gained, the attackers typically scan the network, identify valuable systems, and steal credentials using widely available tools such as Mimikatz. They then move laterally across the network, disable security products, and finally deploy the ransomware to encrypt data.

The key difference in the latest campaign is the use of Guloader, a loader malware that has now been linked to Makop for the first time. Loaders act as a stealthy middle step between the initial breach and the ransomware itself. Instead of immediately dropping the final payload, Guloader operates quietly, often in memory, and downloads additional components only after the attackers are confident they have control.

How to stay safe

The first step to staying safe is securing remote access. RDP services should not be exposed directly to the



in tactics. Researchers have observed Makop adapting its methods to better evade detection and increase success rates, signalling that even established ransomware families continue to refine their operations when they find favourable conditions.

How Makop ransomware works and what makes it different

Most Makop attacks begin with exposed Remote Desktop Protocol

internet wherever possible. Restricting access through a VPN can significantly reduce the attack surface.

Regular patching is another critical defence. Keeping operating systems, servers, and applications up to date closes the vulnerabilities that attackers usually rely on for privilege escalation. Organisations should also routinely audit which of the services that they use are publicly accessible and disable those that are unnecessary. **d**